
LE PIGEON DE PAPIER

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A RETROSPECTIVE

The Past Informs the Future

International tensions have been brewing long before the recent assassination of Austria-Hungary's archduke. What are we to make of growing threats from Germany? To get a better



context for the present and the future, we must look to the past. In this special edition of *Le Pigeon de Papier*, "French Occupation in Northwest Africa", we take a look back at France's imperialistic endeavours along the Atlantic coast of Africa. From the initial conquest of Algeria amidst the July Revolution, all the way to the recent Treaty of Fes, we bring you this retrospective.

FRENCH OCCUPATION IN
NORTHWEST AFRICA

FRENCH OCCUPATION NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER



Early Expansion (1830s–1860s)

French control in Northwest Africa started to take shape in the mid-1800s. In the 1820s, King Charles X was becoming increasingly unpopular with the French populus, leading to the July Revolution of 1830. In an attempt to prove his might to both his people and the rivaling British nation, Charles X wanted to claim territories on the coastline of Algeria. These would provide important control over naval trading routes, and importantly, in theory, improve King Charles's reputation.

In the summer of 1830, France sailed for Algeria and invaded its capital, Algiers. They succeeded in capturing it and other neighboring including the important city of Médéa.

Later, in 1844, the Franco-Moroccan broke out. Following the first French conquest of Algeria, resistance leader Abd Al-Qadir fled to Morocco, inciting the French to follow. The resulting Treaty of Tangiers outlawed Qadir from Moroccan lands.

Governor Louis Faidherbe, in charge of the French forces from 1854 to 1861 and 1863 to 1865, pushed inland from Saint-Louis and Gorée, setting up forts along the Senegal River. His work turned coastal trading into deeper military and political control, pulling Mauritania and the western Sahel into France's orbit.

FRENCH OCCUPATION NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER

The Battle of Isly (1840s)

Emir Abdelkader, Algerian leader of French resistance, took refuge in Morocco in 1844 to avoid conflicts in the heavily French-controlled Algeria. To assist Algeria's fight against the French, Morocco sent troops to the Algerian front, however the French were still maintaining an advantage. In response, France bombarded the two Moroccan territories of Tangier and Mogador on August 4th and 15th respectively.

On September 10th, 1844, the Treaty of Tangier was signed between the French and Moroccans. The treaty stated that French presence in Morocco would be recognized, and Morocco would not aid any enemies of France. This allowed France to exert more power in Morocco and forced Morocco to attack Emir Abdelkader, the main proponent of French resistance in Algeria and Morocco, and surrender him to the French two years later, when he again sought refuge in Morocco.

The Battle of Isly and its related endeavours have been dubbed the Franco-Moroccan War.



FRENCH OCCUPATION NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER



Battle of Smala (1840s)

In May, 1843, Henri d'Orléans lead about 500 French troops to raid Emir Abdelkader's personal encampment while he was absent. They captured about 5500 prisoners, Emir Abdelkader's war chest, and his personal library valued at around 5000 Pounds. Later that year, Emir Abdelkader fled to Morocco to seek refuge from the French

Battle of Sidi-Brahim (1840s)

From September 22nd to 25th, 1845, Emir Abdelkader led about ten thousand Algerian troops in an ambush near Souahlia against about 500 French soldiers under the command of Lieutenant-Colonel Lucien de Montagnac. The Algerians celebrated a resounding victory, with about 400 French killed and about 100 captured as prisoners.

FRENCH OCCUPATION NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER



Mokrani Revolt & African Pushback (1870s)

Mass famine and societal mismanagement in the 1860s within areas of Algeria primarily under French control led to public distaste for French governance. In 1871, after the Franco-Prussian war left France distracted in trying to recuperate its losses, a conglomerate of Algerian tribes led by Mohammed El-Mokrani of the Kabyle Tribe launched a revolt against the French presence in Algeria. Despite French being recently

weakened, they were able to maintain a strong foothold in Northern Algeria and exiled many of the participating tribal leaders to New French Caledonia, off the East coast of Australia.

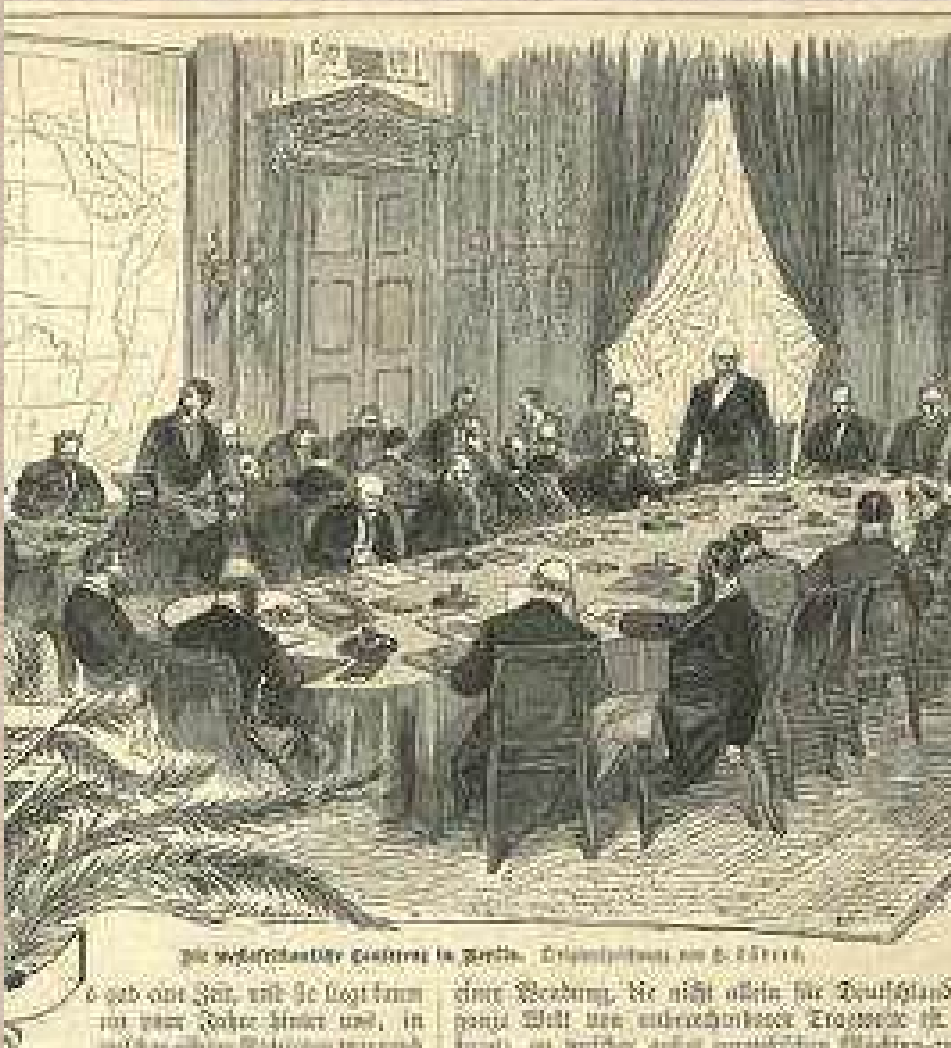
The Scramble & the Berlin Conference (1880s–1890s)

By the 1880s, the Scramble for Africa pushed France further into action. The Berlin Conference in 1878 required “effective occupation” for territorial claims, so France moved to secure the Niger and interior routes before Britain could expand out of Gambia. (Continued on next page)

FRENCH OCCUPATION NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER



The Scramble & the Berlin Conference (1880s– 1890s) (cont.)

Knowing that their control over Algeria had been unstable in recent years, France thought it would be advantageous to secure land in the bordering nation of Tunisia. Furthermore, both Britain and France were concerned about Italy having control over both sides of the Strait of Sicily, which would've required coastal land in both Sicily and Tunisia.

The Berlin Conference, which was additionally focussed on handling Russian influence in the Balkans, served as an opportunity for Britain and France to converse about the problem. Since Britain already maintained the island colony of Malta, it was secretly agreed that if France were to take Tunisia, Britain would not interfere. German complicity in the plan was also realized. From the French perspective, this was especially desirable because it meant that they could keep an eye on both Sicily and Malta, in addition to gaining important coastal land.

In 1881, a host of 30000 men under command of French General Foregemol de Bostquénard entered Tunisia, following which the official protectorate was established.

In 1895, Paris created French West Africa (AOF), grouping Senegal, French Sudan (Mali), French Guinea, and Côte d'Ivoire under the Governor-General.

FRENCH OCCUPATION NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER

Paul Flatters and the Saharan Expeditions (1880s-1900s)

In 1881, amid the invasion of Tunisia, a group led by Paul Flatters journeyed through southern Algeria into the Sahara, with plans to survey the land with the prospect of constructing a trans-Saharan railroad. Due to intense political divide over the Algerian opinion of the French however, Flatters and most of his team were violently murdered by Tuareg tribesmen. To reduce the possibility of events like this happening again, France wanted to expand their Algerian influence southwards towards the Sahara. In 1902, the French succeeded in conquering the Algerian Sahara and defeated the Tuareg tribes led by Kel Ahaggar.



Next Page:

**French Protectorate of Morocco is
Established (1910s)**

FRENCH OCCUPATION NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER



French Protectorate of Morocco is Established (1910s)

The French invasion of Morocco was primarily motivated simply by a desire of France to secure its other territories in northwest Africa. However, France also saw Morocco as an important source of soldiers and military personnel. In 1911, after pressure from France, Morocco at long last signed the Treaty of Fes, which establish the French protectorate there. Morocco believed that they would still be granted reasonable autonomy and self-governance, but the French had other plans.

In reality, the treaty was closer to the previous Treaty of Bardo, which established France's protectorate in Tunisia 30 years earlier. It effectively gave France control over the whole government of Morocco. The next year, following negotiations, France gave Spain a comparatively small section of its protectorate in Morocco. The treaty that facilitated this was aptly named, "The Treaty Between France and Spain regarding Morocco".

Many European superpowers wanted a stake in Morocco; it has an advantageous position on the connection between the Atlantic Ocean and the Mediterranean Sea. France got the largest slice by agreeing to stay out of Britain's way in Egypt, out of Italy's way in Libya, and appeased Spain by giving them northern Morocco.

FRENCH OCCUPATION

NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER

Resistance and Control (1904–1914)

Resistance still broke out, especially in Mauritania and Niger, and French troops put it down. The indigénat system enforced special colonial penalties, head taxes, requisitions, and forced labor, and chiefs who refused to cooperate were replaced by men chosen by French officials. By 1910, most of Northwest Africa was under firm colonial rule. Exports like peanuts, cotton, palm products, and gum arabic moved steadily to Europe, but that “stability” followed years of revolts and heavy-handed campaigns.



On the Eve of War (1914–1915)

By 1914, Dakar had become a modern port city with warehouses, railways, and a naval base. When war broke out, it served as a naval and shipping hub: French ships patrolled the Atlantic from its harbor, and food, fuel, and raw goods moved through the port to Europe. The Tirailleurs Sénégalais were recruited as one of France's early colonial forces on European fronts; by 1918, about 192,000 had been recruited from French West Africa, with roughly 134,000 fighting in Europe. Taxes and labor demands increased during the time of war, causing unrest, but for France it meant the colony was tied into the war effort from the start.

FRENCH OCCUPATION

NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER

Abd Al-Aziz

In 1901 Abd Al-Aziz became the Sultan of Morocco. He was surrounded by European advisors, their influence making him think highly of European ideals. His pursuit of European traditions led him to ridicule elite and religious Moroccan subjects, and failed attempts to implement new taxes on agriculture and livestock. These attempts resulted in rebellious spirits in many native tribes, leading to instability in the country.



Abd Al-Hafid

Abd Al-Aziz's brother, Abd Al-Hafid, grew tired of Abd Al-Aziz's European sympathies and began to rebel. In 1908, his rebellion prevailed, and he was given the title of Sultan. Abd Al-Hafid wasn't able to hold the country together, and in 1911, In Fez, he was attacked in a Tribal rebellion. Facing too strong of forces, he was forced to Call on the French for aid.



FRENCH OCCUPATION NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER

Emir Abdelkader

Born September 6th, 1808, in El Guetna, Algeria, Emir Abdelkader grew up in a religious household belonging to the Qadiriyya Sufism Order. His education was a normal, religious one, in which he excelled as a gifted student. He memorized the entire Qur'an (the main 114 chapter-long Islamic religious text) at the age of 14. At 15, he decided to move to Oran to further his education. In 1832, in the midst of some civil unrest, he was elected Amir al-Mu'minin (Commander of the Faithful), and took lead of the war of harassment against the French.

Qadiriyya Sufi Order

The Qadiriyya Sufi Order is one of the most influential Sufi orders. It was founded in the 12th century by Abdul Qadir Gilani. Abdul Qadir Gilani founded the Qadiriyya order by bridging two of the four main Islamic schools of thinking, Hanbali and Shaf'i.



FRENCH OCCUPATION NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER

Emir Abdelkader in the Military



In 1834, Emir Abdelkader signed the Desmichels Treaty, which gave him the whole interior of Oran. Over the next three years, he conquered more territory and defeated multiple French generals, including General Camille Trézel. In 1837, he convinced the French General Bugeaud, through able negotiating, to sign the Treaty of Tafna. The Treaty of Tafna increased his territory and influence even more.

Emir Abdelkader used various Guerilla warfare tactics in his battle strategies, like ambushes in the Battle of Macta. He had a major focus on using terrain to his advantage, catching enemies unexpected and with little maneuverability. He was also a gifted public speaker, able to unify tribes to fight back against the French (which wasn't very hard, as there was already much discontent with the French in Algeria).

FRENCH OCCUPATION

NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER

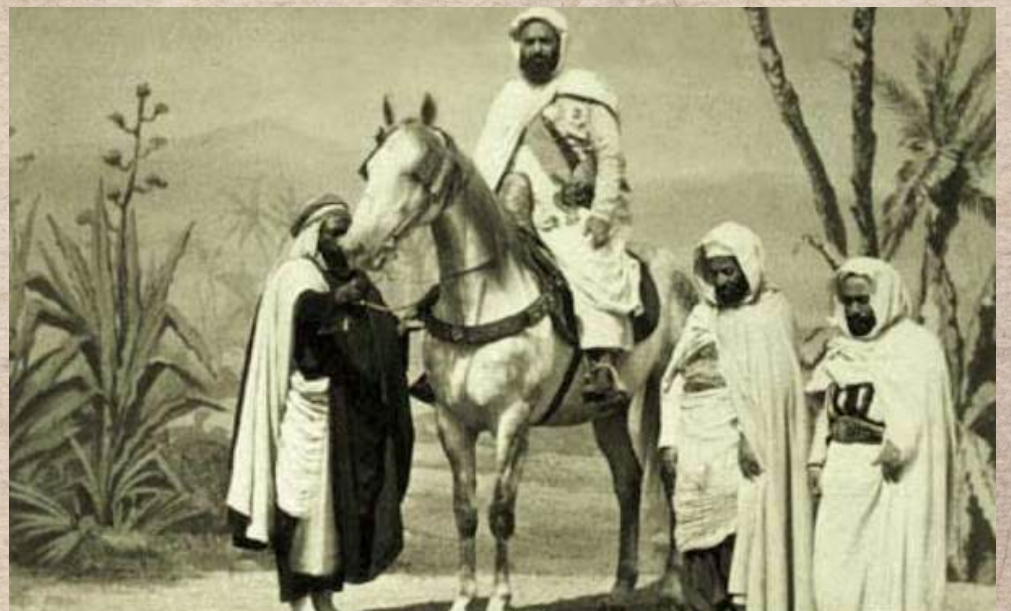
A Legacy to Remember

Emir Abdelkader is often regarded as a hero and symbol of resistance and moral leadership among Islamic communities. He led many fights against French colonists and united many native Algerian tribes into one “true state.” He created a fair justice system and introduced equal taxation, fighting privileges previously given to warlike tribes.

Emir Abdelkader was able to build his “true state” with financial help from the French, whom he eventually rebelled against. Using French money and weapons, he set up a small textiles industry and army, which grew with his resistance’s popularity.

Emir Abdelkader’s Finale

After Emir Abdelkader fled to Morocco in 1843, the French forced a Moroccan sultan to sign a treaty that prohibited Morocco from aiding French enemies, mainly Emir Abdelkader. In 1846, he again needed to flee Algeria to seek refuge in Morocco but was taken captive and given to the French by Moroccan officials. In 1847, he surrendered to the French on terms of exile from Algeria, and he lived out the rest of his life in Damascus, Syria.



FRENCH OCCUPATION NORTHWEST AFRICA

TUESDAY, 11 AUG 1914

LE PIGEON DE PAPIER

The Last 100 Years: A Look Back

Disclaimer: This section is intentionally biased to reflect attitudes of the time.

Beginning in the 1830s and continuing up until this glorious year of 1914, our country of France has steadily conquered and brought northwestern Africa under its domain. From the taking of Algiers by King Charles X and Louis-Philippe, to France's success in the Franco-Moroccan War, to the rebuttal of the Makrani Revolt in spite of the troubles with Prussia, to the fruits of the Berlin Conference ending with French control over Tunisia, to the eventual revenge in the Sahara for the Flatters homicide, to the Treaty of Fes manifesting the Moroccan French Protectorate, France has gained immense control over the north African coast as well as important inland territories.

We expect our country's international imperialist aptitude to show once again in this brewing war. Once we all settle down for Christmas, we'll be able to reflect on this new chapter of our country's history. The only question is, will you be an author?

